

Episode 111: New Year Special Edition – *Strong World ONE PIECE FILM*

Notes (Part 1)

Happy New Year!

How did everyone spend their New Year's?

As for me, I wrapped up work quickly on the 26th and enjoyed my first completely work-free New Year's in years.

Actually, the editorial department asked me to participate in the usual "New Year's cards from familiar faces" again this year, but sorry! I completely blew it off (sweat). Actually, this year I completely gave up on New Year's cards altogether.

Having abandoned even New Year's cards for a relaxing New Year's, well, thanks to that, I became a bigger person! (Mass-wise, that is... (sob))

Now then.

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM, which was released last month, became a big hit thanks to everyone. I don't know the detailed numbers, but anyway, lots of customers came to theatres and watched it.

As I wrote before, we staff are well aware that the initial momentum of this big hit was due to the effect of the comic "Volume 0" admission gift, but even if that was the trigger, having so many people watch the work we created and sent out is above all a joyful thing.

So this time, these are my "*Strong World* notes." I really need to write this down somewhere before I forget.

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At the end of March last year (I wrote April in the theatres pamphlet, but it seems it was actually late March), when the cherry blossoms were in full bloom, the main theatrical staff including the director visited Oda Eiichiro-sensei's workplace somewhere in Tokyo. Of course, this was my first time meeting sensei. I was quite nervous (wry laugh).

The thing is, I joined the theatrical *ONE PIECE* at Director Sakai's request, but actually, I had never read *ONE PIECE* before!!

I'd only caught a glimpse of the TV anime on a restaurant TV while eating sometime, and when my wife and I went to see *CLANNAD* movie, I saw a One Piece movie trailer and was super shocked to learn for the first time that Chopper was a reindeer! Despite being in this industry and having worked at Toei Animation (東映アニメーション) until last year, I was an extremely rare person who knew absolutely nothing about *ONE PIECE* at this stage. So naturally I was nervous facing the original creator himself (wry laugh).

Oda-san quietly spoke to us staff about various aspects of this project. From the situation surrounding *ONE PIECE*, particularly the theatrical versions, to his own feelings about theatrical adaptations. After that, we staff and Oda-san exchanged opinions about content questions and concerns. During this, the director introduced me and I spoke a bit about "colour."

"Actually, I've never encountered the work *ONE PIECE* before..." I started honestly (laugh). "Are there any points about 'colour' you'd like me to pay attention to, or any requests?" I asked.

"No, please feel completely free. Just 'excitement.' I want a feeling that's exciting above all," Oda-san said. That became one of my starting points.

By the time I joined the project, character concept sketches from Oda-san were mostly complete, and Character Designer & Chief Animation Director Sato was organising and cleaning them up for animation. We scanned those, and then—colours. First, the base colours for main and regular characters' skin, hair, eyes, etc.

For *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!* movie that I'd worked on the previous year, the basic direction was "don't stray too far from the TV series" and "upgrade for theatrical work while maintaining the TV impression," so I modified the TV series colour base to look good on screen. But in addition to what Oda-san had told us, Director Sakai also said "Please do it the way you think best, Tsujita-san!" So I decided to think about it from a completely clean slate. In this situation, not knowing *ONE PIECE* was actually a strength (laugh).

So I deliberately didn't use the existing TV series or previous theatrical versions' colour direction (色指定) as reference or foundation. That said, since it was an "original work adaptation," I couldn't completely ignore the original and do whatever I wanted, so I bought the three available colour illustration collections by Oda-san (←out of my own pocket (laugh)) and decided to try my hand at it using those colours as reference.

The colour illustration collection "COLOUR WALK"—this was great! The exciting three-dimensionality and dynamism that manga characters gain by having "colour."

While flipping through that colour illustration collection, I remembered Director Sakai's words: "I think it would be good if it came together with colours that feel 'transparent.'" Ah, I see. So this is what the director wants. Watercolour-touch colours that feel clear, but with solid presence. Could we somehow achieve this unique atmosphere on screen? That's what I thought about.

While thinking about such things, I built up the main characters' base colours. I lined up faces of all nine people (yes, nine people!) on screen, adjusting balance by making this one darker or that one lighter, repeating fine adjustments to aim for that colour illustration collection's atmosphere. First I balanced Luffy and Nami, then placed the

other members' colours. As a result of being conscious of the colour illustrations' transparency, first Luffy's skin became brighter than previous anime versions. With that balance, Zoro and Robin also ended up with considerably brighter skin tones. Oh, Brook and Chopper didn't change much as a result (laugh).

I showed the completed main characters to Director Sakai and the assistant directors for now. How would these colour balance look to people who had become familiar with these characters through the TV series? I was primarily curious about their impressions.

"Hmm!" said Director Sakai. "Could you make Nami's hair colour a bit darker?" Plus some other small requests about everyone's eye colours. "Well, let's go with this for now," and so the base colours were tentatively decided.

With base colours decided, next was creating colours for Luffy and the others' costumes this time, plus the other main character—the enemy characters like Golden Lion Shiki. I made them in sets like "adventure outfit set," "shipboard outfit set," "raid suit set," and "Shiki set." With all of Luffy's group being nine people, it was quite challenging.

First, I created "adventure outfits" and "shipboard outfits" with colours I'd conceived myself. Plus Shiki and the others. Similarly, I showed these to the directors and exchanged opinions. Then it was time to show them to Oda-san.

Oda-san is extremely busy. Ideally we'd have had him come to the studio to see them directly and exchange various feedback, but "that's absolutely impossible! Impossible! Impossible!" So we decided to arrange the finalised character colour samples by set in comparison charts on single sheets, print them out, send them to Oda-san, and get his response.

Computer monitors and printed paper naturally have completely different colour reproduction. So I corrected the image colours for printing to print in colours close to how they looked on the monitor screen, and used slightly better paper to create an

"Oda-san check print set" to send to him. Now, how would Oda-sensei's feedback turn out?

After waiting several days, the long-awaited response from Oda-sensei came back. But...

(10.01.05)